



whites for India. But as I look back, it brings memories of how we prepared for a match. Soon after playing a few games at the highest level, I realised there could be no substitute for solid preparation. Ashwin and I would often spend hours in the nets, even after the regular sessions were over. He would bowl, and I would keep — this was our way of getting ready for a game.

What defines Ashwin is his openness to suggestions from the wicketkeeper and his willingness to tweak accordingly. He often told me he trusted me and felt comfortable when I was behind the stumps. That bond was reflected in our performances, with me being involved in 21 of his dismissals — 18 catches and three stumpings.

I have always observed bowlers in the nets, and every time Ashwin bowled, I watched his action and how he generated bounce and turn from a surface, preparing myself accordingly. These minute observations helped me adapt to the conditions and improve, and we

Trusted ally: Wriddhiman Saha revealed that Ravichandran Ashwin often expressed his trust and comfort when Saha was behind the stumps.

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always made it a point to discuss strategies and back-up plans before a game. This helped us overcome the odds during crucial situations.

There have been times when I missed a catch or failed to effect a stumping, but I never saw Ashwin getting angry. Instead, he would walk up, pat me on the back, and encourage me to do better. When you get that kind of support from a colleague, you feel motivated and it brings out the best in you.

I particularly enjoyed keeping when Ashwin bowled to left-handed batters from around the wicket. It often threw challenges my way as well. It was essential to closely monitor the seam position as the ball would often skid and castle the stumps or produce sharp edges. Those deliveries were masterpieces that Ashwin could create with ease.

From 2014 to 2018, I was the keeper for most of Ash's bowling

spells. It was a privilege to watch him emerge as one of the best in the business. His dedication to the game has been exemplary, and I have always admired how he prepared and remained deeply involved.

We have shared many moments, from glorious victories to heartbreaking defeats. Those times in the dressing room and on the pitch only strengthened our partnership and friendship.

At some point, all of us must hang up our boots and step into a new innings. Knowing Ashwin, I am sure he will remain connected to the game in some way. But every time we watch Test cricket hereon, he will be deeply missed.

One of India's finest and a truly hard-working cricketer — thank you for all the memories, Ashwin. I am glad to have been part of your journey!

As told to Shayan Acharya